The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: EPA

The **ceasefire** in the **Middle East** teetered as **Iran** threatened to withdraw from the agreement. The Islamic Republic said Israel's continued offensive in Lebanon violated the deal and halted shipping traffic through the Strait of Hormuz in response. On Wednesday Lebanese authorities said Israeli strikes had killed more than 250 people. **Hizbullah** said it launched rockets at Israel in response.

The White House said **J.D. Vance** would lead America's **talks with Iran** in Pakistan at the weekend. America's vice-president said there had been a "legitimate misunderstanding" by Iran about whether Lebanon was included in the truce. Meanwhile Donald Trump said that American forces would "remain in place" around Iran until a "REAL AGREEMENT" is reached.

News of the faltering ceasefire and the continued blockade of the Strait of Hormuz weighed down on markets. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped back towards $100 a barrel. Stockmarkets in Europe and Asia also fell modestly.

Mr Trump blasted NATO following a meeting with the alliance's leader, Mark Rutte, in Washington. Mr Trump accused NATO of not being there for America "when we needed them". Mr Rutte said he

had a “very frank” meeting with the president, but did not comment on whether Mr Trump would act on his previous threat of removing America from the alliance.

Fast Retailing, the parent company behind **Uniqlo**, a Japanese clothing brand, reported a 31.7% rise in its operating profit in the six months to February, compared with a year earlier. The firm is on track for its fifth consecutive year of record earnings. But the Iran war’s fueling of oil prices may be a problem for Uniqlo, which uses oil-derived polyester in many of its clothes.

Meta released a new AI model. “Muse Spark” will not compete with rivals’ top models, but is tailored to draw on content posted to the firm’s social networks. On Tuesday Anthropic said its new “Mythos” model was too powerful to be made available to the public. The American lab claims to have been alarmed by its software-hacking capabilities.

The **number of births** in **America** fell by 1% in 2025 compared with a year earlier, to 3.6m, according to the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention. The birth rate also fell by 1%, driven by a larger drop in teen pregnancies, even as births by women over 30 rose slightly. The rate has long been falling; it dropped below 2.1—the level required to keep the population stable without immigration—almost two decades ago.

Figure of the day: 0.02 points, the rise in the EIU’s global democracy index in 2025—one of the biggest increases since 2012. Read the full story.

Photograph: Reuters

Iran after the truce

The ceasefire declared on Wednesday may be fleeting: later that day Iran again struck Gulf states and, after Israel struck Lebanon, it kept the Strait of Hormuz closed. Yet if the truce stabilises, it could lead to an Iran that treats its citizens, neighbours and foes differently.

The balance of power has shifted from Iran's clerics to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Although the IRGC's domestic grip is as tight as ever, there are signs the regime is shaking off some of the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's strictures. Shortly after the ceasefire began, authorities freed a long-term political prisoner. Its henchmen let secular Iranians join their rallies. And state television broadcast interviews with unveiled women.

The direction of travel is far from settled. Hardliners are almost certain to push back against any hint of compromise, and the economic damage from the war could reignite public discontent. Much will hinge on whether the ceasefire holds.

Photograph: Reuters

Questioni for Meloni

Giorgia Meloni, Italy's prime minister, appears in parliament on Thursday for the first time since her right-wing government lost a referendum in March. That poll was nominally about changes to the judiciary but morphed into a vote on her policies in general. The defeat suggests that Italians are growing increasingly dissatisfied with their government.

Casting around for someone to blame, Ms Meloni forced a minister to resign. But it punctured the aura of political invincibility she has acquired since taking office in 2022. Lawmakers will therefore be keen to hear Ms Meloni's plans for the rest of her time in office, which must end by late 2027. So far, she has dismissed speculation about calling the election early, before the damage to Italy's economy from the conflict in the Middle East becomes truly apparent. A plan to change electoral laws in her favour has lost momentum since the referendum result. Attempting to restart it will be tricky.

Photograph: Getty Images

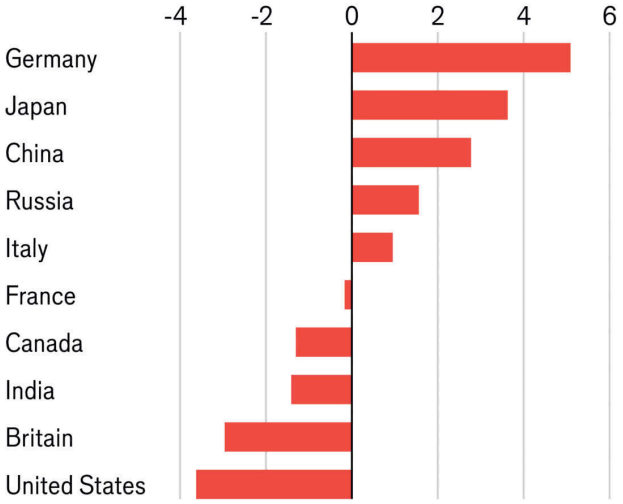
The world’s spring economic stocktake

Scores of finance ministers and central bankers are preparing to gather in Washington, DC, for the spring meetings of the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank. Kristalina Georgieva, the IMF’s managing director, will raise the curtain with a speech on Thursday. She and the fund’s economists, who release their outlook for the world economy next Tuesday, will be scrambling to analyse the ceasefire between America and Iran, which has caused the price of oil to slump by about 15%.

The delegates also have other fissures in the world economy to examine. The fund’s research department has just published a paper lamenting “persistent and recently widening global imbalances”. Big current-account surpluses and deficits—most importantly in China and America respectively—are creating financial vulnerabilities. The answer, the authors argue, is not tariffs or industrial policy but synchronised rebalancing: tighter budgets in deficit countries, more consumption in surplus countries and more investment elsewhere. Getting the patients to take their medicine may be hard.

The red and the black

Current-account balance as % of GDP
2026 estimate



Source: IMF

Illustration: David Simonds

Now watch these drives

The Masters is the first of golf's four big annual tournaments. Its picture-perfect setting in Augusta, Georgia, inspires a civility sometimes missing from other contests, where spectators are more likely to heckle players and cheer foozles. But competition is fierce. When it starts on Thursday, Rory McIlroy, an Irishman, will be looking to defend his title (and win another famous, if unflattering, green jacket); his trickiest opponent may be Scottie Scheffler, an American and the world number one.

The sport's biggest rivalry (off the course at least) has cooled recently: that between America's PGA Tour and LIV Golf, a flashy upstart league funded by Saudi Arabia. Players from both tours compete in the Masters. After high-profile defections by PGA players to LIV, some are returning visor-in-hand, having missed the prestige and attention that the PGA provides. One, Brooks Koepka, had to donate $5m to charity as penance. The PGA once saw LIV as a bunker-size hazard; now it looks more like a divot hole.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: In which Massachusetts town did witch trials occur in 1692-93?

Wednesday: Which actress played Princess Leia in the "Star Wars" films?

The words of kindness are more healing to a drooping heart than balm or honey.

Sarah Fielding